

ALL FOR BAL
(From left) CM Shinde at the function in Vidhan Bhawan; Uddhav at a parallel reception in Colaba

THE OTHER THACKERAYS

JAIDEV THACKERAY
Bal Thackeray's second son is an artist and collector of smoking pipes. Estranged from his father, he was left out of Balasaheb's will. Is a Shinde supporter

SMITA THACKERAY
Jaidev's ex-wife held huge sway in the Sena in the 1990s. Edged out by brother-in-law Uddhav, she left Matoshree in 2008

NIHAR THACKERAY
A lawyer and son of the late Bindumadhav, Balasaheb's eldest son. Part of the legal team representing the Shinde faction in the Supreme Court

JAYDEEP THACKERAY
Jaidev's son from his first wife Jayashree Kalelkar, and an art director. Is supporting Uddhav

KIRTI PATHAK
Daughter of Balasaheb's sister, Sanjeevani Karandikar, she has sided with cousin Uddhav. Pune-based Pathak works for the Shiv Sena women's wing

56 MLAs and 13 of 19 Lok Sabha MPs joining his faction, later named BSS.

On January 23, the late Sena supremo's 97th birth anniversary, members of the Thackeray family like Jaidev Thackeray (second son), Smita Thackeray (Jaidev's second wife), Anuradha Thackeray (Jaidev's third wife), Nihar Thackeray (grandson via the deceased eldest son, Bindumadhav) and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray (nephew), were present at a function to unveil Balasaheb's portrait in the Maharashtra legislature. Uddhav was notably absent despite being invited for the event. Chandrakant Vaidya, the maternal uncle of the Thackeray cousins (Uddhav and Raj are first cousins twice over), was also present along with a prominent Sena rebel—Union minister and BJP leader Narayan Rane. Though they did not take Uddhav's name, there was no doubt who Shinde, Rane and Raj were taking potshots at in their speeches.

After Shinde toppled Uddhav to become the CM, Smita, Nihar and Jaidev came forward to support him. Nihar, a lawyer, is also part of Shinde's legal team in the Supreme Court where the Sena vs Sena battle is being fought. Shinde has also drawn into his fold Champa Singh Thapa, the helper and shadow of the Sena founder, and Moreshwar Raje, who was Thackeray Sr's personal secretary for almost 35 years. Incidentally, Uddhav kept away from the event in Vidhan Bhawan but attended a function to offer floral tributes to Bal Thackeray's life-size statue near the Regal Cinema in Colaba, which is just a km away.

In an obvious reference to the attempts by the BJP and BSS to appropriate his father, Uddhav, who later addressed a party rally at Sion in central Mumbai, dared Shinde to use a photo of Prime Minister Narendra Modi—who had incidentally soft-launched the coalition's election campaign for the BMC polls days earlier—instead of one of Bal Thackeray to seek votes. "Even if Modi is around, you have accepted that you cannot get votes in Maharashtra without Balasaheb...we are ready, you use Modi's photo and we will use that of our leader Balasaheb. Let us see who Maharashtra supports," said Uddhav.

But Kiran Pawaskar, ex-MLC and BSS secretary and spokesperson, says the drift of his kin towards the other side "proves Uddhav has not succeeded as a leader, as CM, as party president or even as a family elder. It is telling that Uddhav's nephew [Nihar] is appearing against him in the SC on behalf of Eknath Shinde," says

That said, Uddhav's corner also has a few Thackerays. His cousin Kirti Pathak, the daughter of Bal Thackeray's younger sister Sanjeevani Karandikar, and Jaydeep Thackeray, who is Jaidev's son from his first wife Jayashree Kalelkar, have come out in his support. Pathak is also a member of the Shiv Sena women's wing. It has also been pointed out that those throwing in their lot with Shinde had been estranged from 'Matoshree,' the Thackeray residence in Bandra (East) during Bal Thackeray's lifetime. For instance, Smita had quit Matoshree in 2008 after she was overlooked for a Rajya Sabha nomination. Says a senior Shiv Sena (UBT) leader, "They are trying new tricks since the MNS seems to have run its course. They want to make it look like Uddhav is isolated, that even his kin have deserted him. But the MNS could not swing the loyal Sena vote even in its heyday."

Senior journalist Sandeep Pradhan says what emerges from the soap-operatic tussle is "that the BJP and Shinde have realised they can't break this political stalemate without the support of at least a few Thackerays. So, they are trying to take along even apolitical members of the clan to send across a message that Uddhav is isolated among his family". Pradhan also notes that Bal Thackeray had anointed Uddhav as his successor in his last days, so that gives him an edge as far as political legitimacy goes. ■